KPPSC PMS IR Master Notes — Q12: The Covid-19 'New Normal', Global Governance & Globalization

KPPSC PMS • INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS (100 MARKS)
Master Model Solution & Theoretical Deconstruction | 20 Marks Master Answer Guide

Executive Examination Metadata

Parameter	Specification
Target Examination	KPPSC PMS (Provincial Management Service) — Khyber Pakhtunkhwa
Paper & Subject	International Relations (100 Marks Optional — Group 6)
EXAM QUESTIONS LINKED:	• **2022 Q.7:** "The Covid pandemic has introduced the concept of the 'New Normal' in the psycho-social attitudes of the public across the globe. Evaluate its structural impact on international relations, economic globalization, and global governance. (20 Marks)" • **2018 Q.7:** "There are two schools of thought regarding the conjecture of globalization. First, view it as a blessing and a tool for prosperity; the other views it as a tool of frustration. Please elaborate. (20 Marks)"
Syllabus Section	Part A: International Trade & Globalization | Non-Traditional Security
Question Allocation	Attempt 1 of 5 Required (20 Marks | Strict 35-Minute Allocation)
Historiographical / Theoretical Thesis	The Covid-19 pandemic operated as a profound systemic accelerator that shattered the post-Cold War orthodoxy of frictionless hyper-globalization and exposed the vulnerabilities of 'weaponized medical interdependence.' Evaluated through international political economy and non-traditional security frameworks, the pandemic did not foster global collective solidarity; instead, it precipitated the resurgence of the sovereign Westphalian state, triggered aggressive 'vaccine nationalism,' and paralyzed multilateral institutions (WHO) through intense US-China geopolitical blame games. The resulting 'New Normal' in international relations is defined by the securitization of public health, the strategic shift from supply-chain efficiency to 'friend-shoring' resilience, and the entrenchment of fragmented globalization.

🎯 Exam Questions Linked

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Exam Essential Takeaways

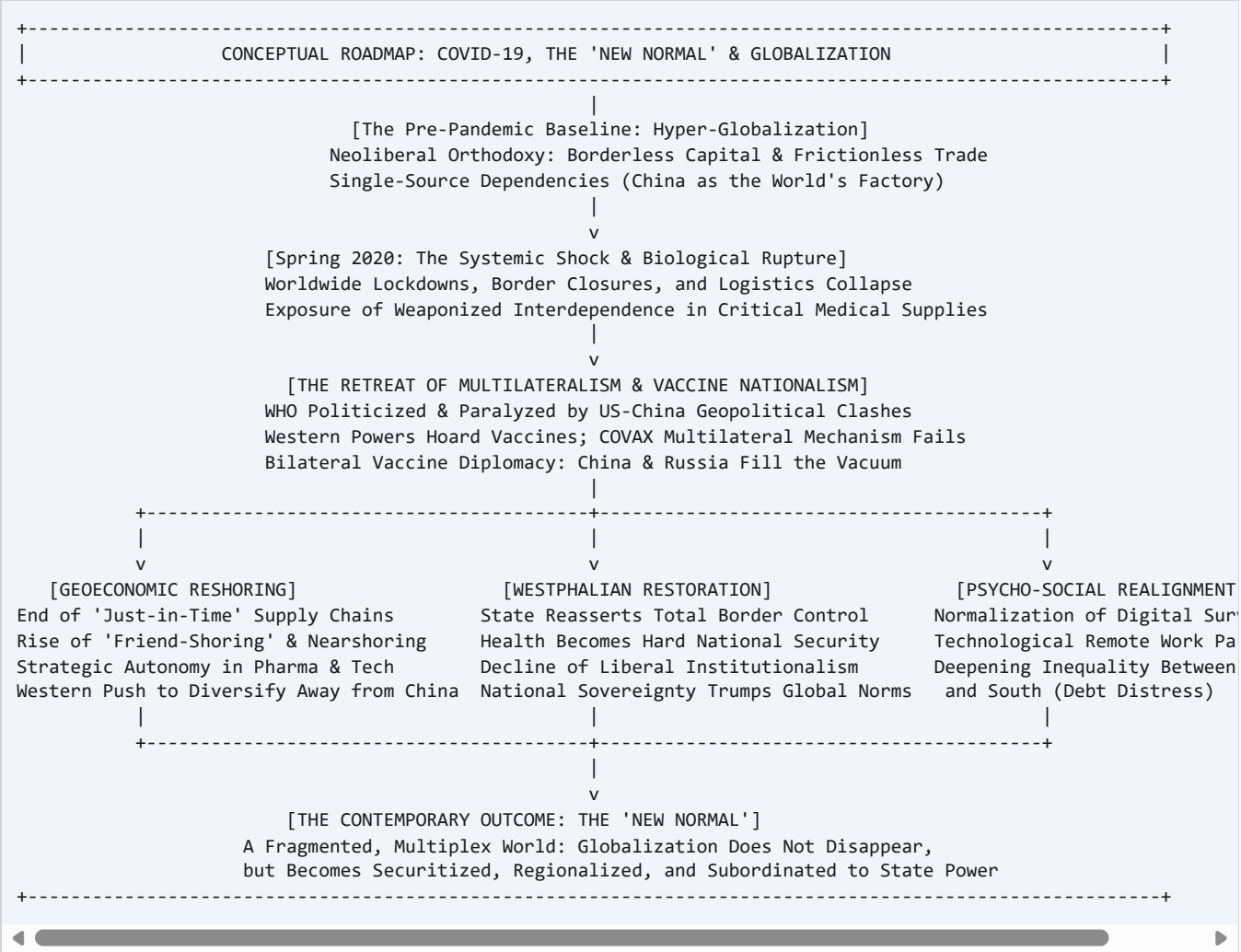
• THE COLLAPSE OF HYPER-GLOBALIZATION: The pandemic shattered the assumption that market efficiency and complex, single-source just-in-time supply chains (concentrated in China) could guarantee national security during biological disruptions.

• THE RESURGENCE OF THE WESTPHALIAN LEVIATHAN: In the face of existential crisis, multilateral governance retreated; the sovereign state reasserted its uncontested primacy through border closures, export bans on personal protective equipment (PPE), and unilateral lockdowns.

• VACCINE NATIONALISM & MULTILATERAL PARALYSIS: Rather than functioning as a neutral global health arbiter, the World Health Organization (WHO) became paralyzed by the US-China geopolitical rivalry, while wealthy nations hoarded vaccines, leaving the Global South to rely on bilateral vaccine diplomacy.

> • THE 'NEW NORMAL' PARADIGM: International political economy has permanently pivoted from 'Just-in-Time' cost minimization to 'Just-in-Case' strategic resilience: nearshoring, onshoring, and friend-shoring critical pharmaceutical, energy, and semiconductor supply chains.

Conceptual Thematic Map & Strategic Roadmap



Analytical Dimensions & Systemic Shifts Matrix

Dimension / Arena	Strategic Mechanism / Driver	Systemic Impact on Global Order
December 2019 – January 2020: Outbreak	Novel coronavirus detected in Wuhan; declared a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC).	Inaugurated the most severe global public health catastrophe since the 1918 Spanish Flu pandemic.
March 2020: Border Closures & Supply Panic	WHO declared global pandemic; over 100 countries enacted border closures and export restrictions on PPE.	Marked the immediate, simultaneous collapse of global civil aviation and supply-chain logistics.
Mid-2020: Geopolitical Weaponization	Trump administration announced withdrawal from WHO; accused Beijing of weaponizing health data.	Transformed a humanitarian health crisis into an intense front of superpower geopolitical rivalry.
2021: Vaccine Nationalism vs Diplomacy	US and Europe prioritized domestic populations; China and Russia launched bilateral vaccine diplomacy in Global South.	Exposed the failure of multilateral global public goods mechanisms like the COVAX facility.
Post-2022: Institutionalization of 'New	G7 enacted supply-chain resilience policies; widespread adoption of digital surveillance and	Formalized the transition from open hyper-globalization to securitized, fragmented

Dimension / Arena	Strategic Mechanism / Driver	Systemic Impact on Global Order
Normal'	hybrid governance.	economic regionalism.

The 20-Mark Master Model Essay (~650-700 Words)

Introduction: The Pandemic as a Systemic Stress-Test for Global Order

The outbreak of the Covid-19 pandemic in early 2020 represented far more than an extraordinary public health emergency; it functioned as a profound systemic stress-test that stripped away the foundational illusions of the post-Cold War international order. For three decades, the ideology of hyper-globalization—championed by neoliberal economists and celebrated in Thomas Friedman's thesis of a 'flat world'—presupposed that cross-border economic integration, market efficiency, and frictionless supply chains had permanently diminished the relevance of the sovereign nation-state. However, the virus struck directly at the nervous system of globalized interdependence. Rather than inspiring a renaissance of multilateral cooperation, the pandemic acted as an intense geopolitical accelerator, exposing deep supply-chain vulnerabilities, entrenching state-centric nationalism, and establishing the 'New Normal' in international relations: a fragmented global architecture where economic efficiency is permanently subordinated to national security, sovereign self-reliance, and strategic resilience.

The Exposure of Hyper-Globalization and Weaponized Interdependence

The primary structural casualty of the pandemic was the doctrine of unconstrained supply-chain optimization. Under neoliberal capitalism, global corporations had constructed hyper-efficient 'Just-in-Time' manufacturing models that concentrated critical production nodes in single geographic locations—predominantly the People's Republic of China. When factories across East Asia shuttered in early 2020, Western states suffered catastrophic shortages of essential medical supplies, pharmaceuticals, and active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs). In international political economy, this revealed the dangerous vulnerability of 'weaponized interdependence.' Western policymakers suddenly realized that over-reliance on a potential geopolitical adversary for life-saving antibiotics and medical equipment constituted an unacceptable national security threat. The resulting disruption catalyzed an urgent, systemic shift toward 'Just-in-Case' supply-chain architectures, driving policies of onshoring, nearshoring, and 'friend-shoring' critical industries within trusted democratic alliances.

The Resurgence of the Westphalian State and Vaccine Nationalism

In the realm of global governance, Covid-19 triggered the dramatic resurgence of the sovereign Westphalian state at the expense of international institutions. In times of existential peril, populations turned not to the United Nations or the European Union, but to their national governments for survival. Sovereign states unilaterally closed borders, requisitioned private manufacturing facilities, and enacted sweeping export bans on ventilators and therapeutics. This nationalist retreat was epitomized by the phenomenon of 'vaccine nationalism.' Despite grand rhetoric celebrating vaccines as 'global public goods,' wealthy industrialized nations pre-purchased billions of doses, severely underfunding the multilateral COVAX facility and leaving developing countries in Africa and South Asia desperately underserved. In the absence of genuine multilateral solidarity, great powers deployed 'vaccine diplomacy' as a transactional geopolitical weapon, with China and Russia leveraging Sinopharm and Sputnik V deliveries to extract political concessions across the Global South.

Institutional Paralysis and Superpower Blame Games

Simultaneously, the pandemic exposed the acute institutional fragility of multilateral organizations in an era of great-power contestation. The World Health Organization (WHO), theoretically designed to serve as a neutral, technical coordinator of global epidemiological defense, became thoroughly paralyzed by the vitriolic geopolitical struggle between the United States and China. The Trump administration accused the WHO of serving as a 'puppet of Beijing' and formally withdrew from the body, while Chinese authorities resisted independent international investigations into the origins of the virus in Wuhan. The politicization of international health governance demonstrated that global institutions cannot function autonomously when great powers decide to treat a humanitarian crisis as a zero-sum propaganda battleground.

Conclusion: The Architecture of the 'New Normal'

In conclusion, the 'New Normal' ushered in by the Covid-19 pandemic does not signify the absolute death of globalization, but its profound, permanent qualitative mutation. Globalization has not ended; it has been securitized, politicized, and fractured into competing regional blocs. The psycho-social attitudes of global populations have

normalized digital surveillance, state border tracking, and skepticism toward external dependencies. In the post-pandemic international order, states recognize that health security, supply-chain resilience, and technological sovereignty are indivisible elements of national power. The romantic era of frictionless, borderless global governance has vanished, replaced by a hardheaded, competitive Westphalian reality where sovereign states must build robust domestic buffers to survive in a turbulent, fragmented world.

Theoretical Perspectives & Quotable Thesis Arguments

Theorist / Scholar	Theoretical School	Exact Quotable Thesis Argument
Dani Rodrik	*The Globalization Paradox*	"The pandemic exposed the fatal flaw of hyper-globalization: the idea that markets can exist without governments. When crisis strikes, the nation-state remains the only legitimate entity capable of providing public protection and economic rescue."
Thomas L. Friedman	*The World is Flat*	"The post-Covid world will be divided into B.C. (Before Corona) and A.C. (After Corona). We learned that a world that is merely connected without resilience is profoundly fragile."
Henry Kissinger	*The Corona Crisis Will Forever Alter the World Order*	"The founding legend of modern government is a walled city protected by powerful rulers. The pandemic has prompted a resurgence of the walled city in an age when prosperity depends on global trade."
Francis Fukuyama	*The Thing That Determines a Country's Resilience*	"The pandemic revealed that state capacity, social trust, and leadership are the ultimate variables of national survival. Ideological systems mattered less than whether a state possessed competent bureaucratic institutions."
Joseph E. Stiglitz	*Globalization and Its Discontents*	"We constructed an economic system that was optimized for short-term corporate profits at the expense of long-term societal resilience. Covid-19 proved that efficiency without security is an existential catastrophe."